



33 The Cyborg Times



37 Archos Gmini400



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Digital Passion

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Lead Feature

O Animator, Who Art Thou?

A sketch, a drawing, some animation and a movie... all in a day's work

Meera Vankipuram

Step into Crest Communications, and your first impression is that it resembles a busy hive. Behold a hundred animators poring into their workstations, heads riveted to their screens—welcome to one of India's biggest and best-known animation studios!

Nestled within a multi-storey building, in upmarket Worli, Mumbai, Crest is home to several budding animators and special effects professionals. Yet, the insanity associated with the art is not reflected in the environment. Bright attire and friendly banter abound, but post 10 am, the cubicles morph into sacred altars where ideas are born—"shhhhhhh," insists someone when I raise my voice to ask for directions.

Is this really the animation studio that earned an Annie Award nomination for *Jakers! The Adventures of Piggley Winks* (a laugh-a-minute cartoon strip broadcast on PBS Kids in the US), and may bag a Disney project soon?

Who are these people we call animators? Digit spent a day with three members from the Crest world to answer: was it all just about Maya and 3DS Max, or is there more to an animator than just fancy hardware and software?

The Cast

Mr Incredible: Upinder Dhaliwal, 24 year old and an Aquarian

Occupation: Animator

Undercover: "Proud Sardarji," with his heart in the Armed Forces

Education: Symbiosis (BCom), Arena Multimedia (Photoshop), Digital Concepts, Pune (3D Studio Max Release 4), Vancouver Film School, Canada (a course in animation)

Buzz Lightyear: Rajarajan, a 24-year-old Piscean

Occupation: Background artiste, Team Leader, R&D

Undercover: An exasperated son still trying to convince his parents that animation is indeed a respectable profession!

Education: VISA Silicon Graphics degree from Pentamedia Graphics (Chennai), diploma in textile design, CAD/CAM courses

Princess Fiona: Shilpa Bobade, a 33-year-old Piscean

Occupation: Composer (2D & 3D)

Undercover: A dotting mom

Education: Degree in Commercial Art from Raheja School of Art, Mumbai

Upinder, Raj and Shilpa are part of the *Jakers!* team, a series that tells the story of Piggley Winks, a cheeky eight-year-old pig, and his friends Dannan the Duck and Ferny the Bull on Raloo Farm in Ireland. A typical team includes eight to 10 animators, two to three background artistes and two rendering artistes. Although there are several stages in the animation process, we focus on three aspects—character animation, background creation and compositing.

To get a fix on what animators exactly do, here's a quick tutorial: an idea is first incubated in the collective head of the producers of a show or a film, who then invite sample showcases (dubbed "pilots") from top studios across the globe. Once a studio wins a project, the team gets down to the basics—drawing board, pencil and paper. Trained artistes then sketch the characters with inputs from the producers and animators.

Making Faces

Character animators create the characters and movements associ-

Shilpa Bobade, Composer

